

THE EXPULSION OF MUSLIMS FROM THE NORTHERN PROVINCE

A Sri Lankan Tamil Perspective

Devanesan Nesiah

I speak as a concerned Sri Lankan Tamil individual with no claim to represent anyone. 'Black October' 1990 was a watershed for North East Muslims, not just Northern Muslims, as such as much as Black July 1983 was for Tamils. Perhaps my ethnic identity, as also that of Kethesh, was considered when the Peace Secretariat for Muslims planned this workshop. Any problem concerning the Muslims, especially those from the North East, concerns Sri Lankan Tamils, just as no solution to the problems of the Tamils, particularly those of the North East, can be worked out without the full participation of the Muslims of that region.

I seek your indulgence to begin on a personal note. I served as the Government Agent for three years each in Mannar (mid '60s), Batticaloa (late '60s and early '70s) and Jaffna (early 80s). In each of these districts the largest ethnic group was Tamil and the second largest Muslim. Tamil-Muslim relations were consistently excellent in Mannar and Jaffna, and excellent in Batticaloa too except for brief, isolated, sporadic incidents of a minor nature.

The situation in the East deteriorated post-1983 with the formation of armed, state-sponsored home guards but, in spite of it, when the civil war broke out in 1985, there were several Muslims among the rebel groups. Many incidents have marred Tamil-Muslim relations since then. But nothing can possibly justify the expulsion of the entire Muslim population from the North in Black October 1990. As a Sri Lankan Tamil with roots in the North, I feel deeply ashamed of it and even more ashamed when some of my friends try to find excuses for the expulsion.

One of the many tragedies arising from the civil war was an escalation of disappearances and vigilante executions. Jezima Ismail, Camillus Fernando and I were mandated by the Human Rights Commission to inquire into a set of disappearances in the North, with M. C. M. Iqbal as our Secretary. We conducted the inquiry and reported in 2003 on the disappearances of 255 Tamils in the period of 1995-

98, for nearly all of which we held the army responsible, and the disappearances of 25 Muslims in 1989-91, for all of which we held the LTTE responsible. The report was published and we also conveyed our findings individually to the families of the victims. But the scars remain, as also the scars of Black October 1990, and of many other atrocities before and since then.

I will not digress any further. What can be done in respect of the Muslims evicted from the North? Ethnic cleansing always leaves an ugly wound, and the best option from the larger perspective, including that of the local population of the ethnic groups yet resident in the area, may be to reverse the ethnic cleansing. The priority is therefore to lower the barriers to the return of those evicted.

It appears as, Mirak illustrated, that the foremost barrier concerns security-fears of renewed violence and recurrence of eviction. There is also the related question of full acceptance of the returnees, by the LTTE (who evicted them) and by the local community (of whom most were uninvolved, and several opposed the eviction). Attitudes may have changed over the years, and there is uncertainty on this account. Return is also contingent on rehabilitation, involving houses, lands, schooling, employment, civic amenities, etc., as well as compensation for losses incurred in the course or on account of eviction.

The security question relates to the entire peace process. Although our focus is on the expulsion of Muslims from the North, all of us are involved, particularly the people of the North and East. If war breaks out, or even if we drift close to the brink of war, who will dare to give a guarantee of the security of anyone in the North or East? Under such circumstances, how credible will be any offer of such a guarantee? The victims of war, or of any political violence under a "no war, no peace" situation may be from all the communities of the region. Perhaps this is why the people of the North and East are overwhelmingly for the strengthening

of the cease-fire and the advancement of the peace process. Despite acute grievances and bitter experiences, and perhaps because of the latter, it is they who are most flexible in their approach to peace, most willing to make accommodations and compromises. Despite old and new grievances, for them war is not an acceptable option. The will to war is mostly among those who do not expect to be in the direct line of fire.

We now turn to the question of what needs to be done to bring justice to the Muslim victims of the Black October 1990.

Muslim- LTTE contacts

Fomer Jaffna Deputy Mayor Basheer identified a vital priority *viz* the difficult but urgent and absolutely critical need to improve the relationship between the Muslim leadership of the North and East and the LTTE leadership. This will be difficult, not only due to bitterness and lack of trust on account of what has already happened, but also on account of likely manipulations by those who, for various reasons, may wish to perpetuate the hostility. Muslims remain, and will continue to remain, an integral part of the North and East. Particularly in respect of that region, the welfare of the Tamils and Muslims are inseparable. There can be no return to normalcy without the return of evicted Tamils and Muslims throughout the North and East.

It is desirable that there are regular meetings between the leaders of the Muslims of the North and East and the LTTE at several levels. Positive fall-outs from such meetings may, hopefully, be an unqualified apology and an unambiguous invitation to the Muslims to return, plus an appreciation by the LTTE of the need for and the value of independent Muslim representation at the peace talks. Tamil-Muslim clashes are only a part of the larger problems of the need for autonomy for the predominantly Tamil-speaking areas constituting the North East region. The Tamil and Muslim leadership of those areas need to resolve the issue of power-sharing between themselves and, jointly, with the centre. The appropriate seating for Muslim representation at the peace talks is not within the government delegation but independent of it.

Inter-religious contacts

Religion has been, and is being, used to fuel conflict, but it also has much underutilized potential to end conflict and to further peace. In comparison with many other

countries, inter-religious conflicts in Sri Lanka do not arise from deep-rooted animosities, and relations between the religious leaders, Buddhist, Hindu, Muslim and Christian, have, by and large, been cordial. There are a few inter-religious organizations and sporadic contacts, but their activities may not extend beyond occasional meetings, mostly in the cities. Very little of the socio-economic development programmes are designed to be inter-ethnic. Particularly in the North and East, there is a need for a broad network of inter-religious institutions engaged in a wide range of ongoing programmes. Such civil society organizations and programmes will help to deter the outbreak of sectarian violence and to lay the foundation for peace building. In the long run these may be more effective than the ad hoc peace committees and other measures hastily adopted in the midst of violence.

That integrated civil society organizations play a critical role in peace building and deterring ethnic riots was one of the central findings of the research conducted by Prof. Varshney of Michigan University into Hindu Muslim riots in India, and set out in his work on the subject. A tragic consequence of ethnic cleansing is segregation, leading to mono-ethnic neighbourhoods, schools and civic institutions replacing inter-ethnic neighborhoods, schools and civic institutions. Developing and promoting the latter is of the highest importance. Hopefully, the Universities of Jaffna, Eastern and South-Eastern will progressively develop programmes designed to promote Tamil-Muslim studies and contacts and eventually attract faculty and students of both communities. We need to see integration and reintegration not as inter-ethnic concessions but as mutual enrichment. The Jaffna I grew up in was richly diverse. Today Jaffna is almost completely drained of that vibrant diversity, and virtually reduced to mono-ethnicity. We need to recover what was lost.

The language bond

A potentially powerful Tamil-Muslim linkage that has been grossly underutilized is the Tamil language. Notwithstanding the support of the southern Muslim leadership for Sinhala- only in Parliament since the mid-1950s, Tamil language is the shared heritage of the Tamils and the Muslims, especially those of the North and East. Both in India and in Sri Lanka, much outstanding original Islamic literature and poetry has been through the Tamil medium; even in the secular field, many of the foremost literary figures, Carnatic musicians and media personnel of Tamil Nadu and Sri Lanka have been Muslims. This is so

even now. Is it not possible to build, on that shared linguistic foundation, creative cultural programmes that will link the two communities ? Our universities, schools, artists, musicians and the media have much to contribute in this area.

Finally, several of the resource persons and many of the participants here are involved in programmes on the ground that directly answer the question posed: "What is to be done?" We are all familiar with some of the admirable work that Dr. Hasbulla, Moulavi Suffian and many others are engaged in. I have not attempted to stretch the areas in which useful

programmes could be founded but, rather, have sought to address the strategic aspects of, broadly, Tamil-Muslim and, more specifically, LTTE- Muslim relations. Strengthening these relationships is a prerequisite to reaching the essential goal of doing justice to the Muslim victims of Black October 1990.

I end with one proposal for immediate attention - some of these issues need to be taken up in Geneva in April. I think they can be gainfully pursued. ■

Dr. Devanesan Nesiah is a researcher & a consultant at the SSA

ATHEISM IS A LEGACY WORTH FIGHTING FOR

Slavoj Zizek

For centuries, we have been told that without religion we are no more than egotistic animals fighting for our share, our only morality that of a pack of wolves; only religion, it is said, can elevate us to a higher spiritual level. Today, when religion is emerging as the wellspring of murderous violence around the world, assurance that Christian or Muslim or Hindu fundamentalists are only abusing and perverting the noble spiritual messages of their creeds ring increasingly hollow. What about restoring the dignity of atheism, one of Europe's greatest legacies and perhaps our only chance for peace?

More than a century ago, in *The Brothers Karamazov* and other works, Dostoyevsky warned against the dangers of godless moral nihilism, arguing in essence that if God doesn't exist, then everything is permitted. The French philosopher André Glucksmann even applied Dostoyevsky's critique of godless nihilism to 9/11, as the title of his book, "Dostoyevsky in Manhattan," suggests.

This argument couldn't have been more wrong: The lesson of today's terrorism is that if God exists, then everything, including blowing up thousands of innocent bystanders, is permitted—at least to those who claim to act directly on behalf of God, since, clearly, a direct link to God justifies the violation of any merely human constraints and considerations. In short fundamentalists have become no different than the "godless" Stalinist Communist, to whom everything was permitted, since they perceived themselves as direct instruments of their divinity, the Historical Necessity of Progress Toward Communism.

Fundamentalists do what they perceive as good deeds in order to fulfill God's will and to earn salvation; atheists do them simply because it is the right thing to do. Is this also not our most elementary experience of morality? When I do a good deed, I do so not with an eye toward gaining God's favor; I do so it because if I did not, I could not look at myself in the mirror. A moral deed is by definition its own reward. David Hume made this point poignantly when he wrote that the only way to show true respect for God is to act morally while ignoring God's existence.

Two years ago, Europeans were debating whether the preamble of the European Constitution should mention Christianity. As usual, a compromise was worked out, a reference in general terms to the "religious inheritance" of Europe. But where was modern Europe's most precious legacy, that of atheism? What makes modern Europe unique is that it is the first and only civilization in which atheism is a fully legitimate option, not an obstacle to any public post.

Atheism is a European legacy worth fighting for, not least because it creates a safe public space for believers. Consider the debate that raged in Ljubljana, the capital of Slovenia, my home country, as the constitutional controversy simmered: should Muslims (mostly immigrant workers from the old Yugoslav republic) be allowed to build a mosque? While conservatives opposed the mosque for cultural, political and even architectural reasons, the liberal weekly journal *Mladina* was consistently outspoken in its support for the mosque, in keeping with its concern for the rights of those from other former Yugoslav republics.

Not surprisingly, given its liberal attitudes, *Mladina* was also one of the few Slovenian publications to reprint the caricatures of Muhammad. And, conversely, those who displayed the greatest “understanding” for the violent Muslim protests those cartoons caused were also the ones who regularly expressed their concern for the fate of Christianity in Europe.

These weird alliances confront Europe’s Muslims with a difficult choice: The only political force that does not reduce them to second-class citizens and allows them the space to express their religious identity are the “godless” atheist liberals, while those closest to their religious social practice, their Christian mirror-image, are their greatest political enemies.

The paradox is that Muslims’ only real allies are not those who first published the caricatures for shock value, but those

who, in support of the ideal of freedom of expression, reprinted them.

While a true atheist has no need to bolster his own stance by provoking believers with blasphemy, he also refuses to reduce the problem of the Muhammad caricatures to one of the respect for others’ beliefs. Respect for others’ beliefs as the highest, value can mean only one of two things: Either we treat the other in a patronizing way and avoid hurting him in order not to ruin his illusions, or we adopt the relativist stance of multiple “regimes of truth,” disqualifying as violent imposition any clear insistence on truth. What about submitting Islam – together with all other religions – to a respectful, but for that reason no less ruthless, critical analysis? This, and only this, is the way to show a true respect for Muslims: to treat them as adults responsible for their beliefs. ■

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Slavoj Zizek, the international director of the Birkbeck Institute for the Humanities, is the author, most recently, of “The Parallax View”

MEMORIES OF DETENTION

We sit in a room,
before the curfew,
and watch the road,
there is silence everywhere

There is a knock
on the weathered door,
and I meet the gaze of
my former acquaintance,
smile the warm welcome of
acceptance

We share a cup of tea,
and talk of the times,
gazing at photographs of
violence and counter-violence,
in that long and deserted
road.

Can this be possible?
I query.
All this violence,
on both sides,
one acquaintance more prone to violence,
abducted in a marketplace
after months of negotiation.

The silence of death
meets my gaze,
torpid in the festering
heat,
where were those trees,
totem poles of silence
to which the burnt out
remains of a man were
tethered?

I do not know?
I witness only the silent
suffering of one
who is trapped in a
world of death.

And what of my acquaintance?
The cups of coffee or tea we
shared at the canteen,
watching the canopied trees
and gurgling brook outside
the canteen are memories
distilled from the past.

I glance once more at the
distant hills and observe
images from the past.

Parvathi Solomons Arasanayagam

HINDU AND MUSLIM CONNECTIONS TO SRI PADA

Premakumara de Silva

The sacredness of Sri Pâda is not only claimed by Buddhists but also by other religious groups such as Hindus, Muslims and Catholics. In this paper I want to explore these non-Buddhist mytho-historical connections, specifically those of Hindus and Muslims. Let me first begin with the Tamil Hindu story.

Sri Pâda is regarded by Hindus as having been made a sacred ground by Lord Siva, one of the supreme gods of the Hindu pantheon. The origin myth of Sri Pâda as a footprint of Siva, popularly known as *Sivan-oli-padam*, *Shivanadipadam Mallei* (mountain of Shiva's footprint) or *Swangarrhanan* (ascent to Heaven), is widely believed among Tamil Hindus in the country. The basis for Tamil Hindu belief in the Sivan-oli-padam, according to the Chief Priest (76) of the Kotahena (north of Colombo) Ponnambalam Vanisvaram Siva temple is this: Siva appeared in his dancing manifestation, on this mountain for the performance of certain devotional austerities, at the end of which, in celebration of his abode there, he left the impression of his foot upon the mountaintop. Another Hindu priest at the Sri Kadiresan temple in the south of Colombo told the following somewhat different story:

When Siva was living in Mount Kailash, a mountain in the Himalayas, he made a journey from the Himalayas to Rameshvaram in South India where he saw that people were poorer than in Sri Lanka. Siva then left Rameshvaram for Sivan-oli-padam, in one of his most popular forms, that of Nataraja (the dancing form), and made his cosmic dance there. As a result, a war broke out, but that war could solve all the malicious things in Sri Lanka because his dance created the sacred footprint for people to venerate that is Sivan-oli-padam.¹

Interestingly, I found another myth of Sivan-oli-padam in the appendix of William Skeen's book *Adam's Peak* (1870). The story seems to be translated from Tamil to English by P.K.T. Kanageratina, MODR, but the writer of the story is unknown. However, it was forwarded to Skeen by H.S.O. Russell, then the Government Agent of the Central Province:

In Ceylon there are places dedicated to Siva such as Trincomalee or Thadchanakaylaysam..., Thirukkachcharam... There is a Puranam... in Sanskrit (which is the mother language of Tamil) relating to Thadchanakaylasam or Trincomalee, called Thadchana-kaylaya-manmeium... The following was recorded in the 6th and 7th chapters of that book. In the middle of the mountain called Sivanolipatham, three rivers or kankai rise out of Sivan's foot... From my (Sivan's) foot, three rivers issue out, and the names are Mavillie-kankai... Manikka-kankai... and Karary-kankai... Mavillie-kankai flows towards the North, reaches Sivan's place at Trincomalee, and falls into the sea south of it. Manikka-kankai flows towards the East and passes by Katherkamum... a place dedicated to Supermania-swamy, son of Siva, and then falls into the eastern sea. Kavary-kankai flows towards the West, and passes into the place of Siva, called Therukkachcharum (situated at Mantotte in Mannar). These three kankais are 'highly meritorious streams'. The names of these three rivers, the directions they take in their course, their connection with the above-named three famous places dedicated to Sivan's worship, the name 'Sivanolipatham' by which this peak is usually known, and the fact of these four places and the three rivers being recognized by Sivaites as places peculiarly adopted for the worship of Siva, at the present as well as in the ancient times, show beyond doubt that the mountain in the Central Province of the Island of Ceylon which is called Sivanolipatham in Tamil — Adam's Peak in English — is the very mountain spoken of in the Sanskrit work Thedchana-kaylaya-manmeium written several centuries ago. (1870: 295-96)

This fascinating story describes the sacred footprint as having been made into a sacred ground of Lord Siva, and it also describes the elaborate Tamil Hindus sacred geography in Sri Lanka. Though the story is said to be taken from one of the ancient Puranas, a prominent Tamil literary scholar in Sri Lanka told me that no such myth appears in any of the eighteen Puranas. Similarly, another distinguished Tamil historian has recently edited a book titled *Temples of Siva in Sri Lanka* with no reference to Siva's connection with the

Sivan-oli-padam (Pathmanathan 1999). Confirmed by the prominent archaeologist and historian S. Paranavitana in his book *The God of Adam's Peak*: "to my knowledge, there is no work of any antiquity which refers to the Footprint on Adam's Peak as that of God Siva" (1957: 21).

This does not mean that there has been no historical claim, or Hindu engagement with, Sri Pâda. For example, the Mahavamsa states that a group of Hindu Saivite priests began to control Sri Pâda under the patronage of the Sinhala king Râjasinha I (1581-95) of the Kotte kingdom (Mv. Ch.93 v 4-17). They controlled Sri Pâda for nearly 160 years before it was handed over to a Buddhist monk by Kîrtisri Râjasinghe (1747-80), himself a Hindu Tamil king, who later became a pious Buddhist king of the Kandyan royal court (Mv. Ch. 100, v.221). Even before that, Ibn Battuta, a Muslim naval trader or traveller stated that, "Arya Chakravarti, the Hindu king of Jaffan, brought with him four *yogis* who were in the habit of visiting the foot-mark every year; and with these they were also accompanied by four Brahmanas and ten of the king's companions" (cf. Paranavitana 1957: 21). This account confirms that Hindus made the pilgrimage to Sri Pâda by the 14th century, and even before.² But the point I want make here is that, unlike the Mahavamsa, any Tamil claim on Sri Pâda, or more precisely Sivan-oli-padam, has not been prominent in their terrain of mytho-historical knowledge production. This confirms Daniel's suggestion that the Tamil Hindu conception of history puts more emphasis on heritage than on concrete history, which is emphasized by Sinhala Buddhist (1989: 22).

Although the authoritative tradition of Tamil Hindus in Sri Lanka, and even south India, has simply forgotten or dropped the mythology of Siva's connection with the Sivan-oli-padam, it is still popular among Hindu priests and the wider Tamil Hindu community in Sri Lanka. For example, popular myths among estate Tamils, who mostly live in the central hill-country, interchangeably claim the sacred footprint as that of the god Siva and of the god Vishnu. Their annual ritual journey to Sri Pâda is more explicitly rooted in their belief in the footprint as that of Vishnu. I found that the myth of Vishnu³ is predominantly popular among plantation Tamil Hindus, while the myth of Siva is popular among non-plantation Tamil Hindus.

The Muslims of Sri Lanka believe that the sacred footprint is that of Adam; more precisely they call it 'Baba-adam-mallei' (footprint of Adam). Their engagement with the sacred mountain can be traced

back to early Arabic writings of travellers and traders.⁴ However, the general belief about the mythical origin of the sacred footprint is that, after Adam and Eve ate the forbidden fruit and were expelled from the Garden of Eden, Adam was further punished by being forced to stand on one foot on the mountaintop.⁵ This long ordeal left the print of Adam's foot on the mountain. Adam's fall from Paradise is mentioned several times in the Koran. G. Sale says in his translation of the Koran: The Mohammedans say that when they were cast down from paradise, Adam fell on the isle of Ceylon or Serendib, and Eve near Joddah (the port of Mecca) in Arabia; and that after a separation of 200 years, Adam was, on his repentance, conducted by the angel Gabriel to a mountain near Mecca, where he found and knew his wife, the mountain being thence named Arafat, and that he afterwards retired with her to Ceylon, where they continued to propagate their species. (D'herbelot, Bib.Orient: 55) (Sale, London 1734: 6 n6)⁶

A similar story was narrated somewhat differently by a Muslim priest (Lebbe: 65) of a village mosque from Kahattagasdigiliya in the North Central Province, together with two fellow priests, at the Sri Pâda temple. He narrated the story in Sinhala: The God Allah told Adam and Eve, 'You do what ever you want to do, but don't eat the fruit (*gedi*) of the Forbidden Tree.' But they did not pay attention to the word of Allah and they ate the fruit. Then Allah said, 'You did the wrong thing so I expel you from heaven to earth (*bimata*)'. When they were expelled from heaven to earth, Adam put his first footstep on this [Adam's] peak, and his other footstep on the Kuragala.⁷ Eve put her footstep on to Mecca [*makkama*]. At the time they came here, no one lived on the earth. They were crying for seven days. Their tears ran down to the sea and some turned into precious gems (*menik una*). They accepted their wrong-doing, and then God Allah brought them together. At that point they felt hungry. Then God Allah sent a messenger (*deva dutaya*) to the earth to explain to them the basic cultivation techniques. After the course of time they had two children; one was a boy and the other a girl. Then they got married and had children; so the human world was created. That is why we believe this footprint is that of Adam, the footprint of the first man on the earth.

Such a claim can be further explored through the knowledge produced by voyagers, missionaries, traders and travellers,

who had historically interacted with Sri Pâda. The narratives those figures produced I collectively refer to as “diasporic narratives.” The diasporic narratives show us how the Muslim association with Sri Pâda was historically established and then flourished.

The history of the Muslims of Sri Lanka is part of the history of Arab civilization in the East.⁸ From the middle of the 6th century CE, the expansion of Arab commercial activities in the Indian Ocean gradually caused the expansion of Muslim settlement in south India and Sri Lanka (see Kamil Asad 1993; Devaraja 1994; McGilvray 1999). However, the earliest Muslim engagement at Sri Pâda, according to Paranavitana, was reported in the 851 CE travel account of the Arab merchant Soleyman. In this account it states, “It is thought Adam ascended, and there left the print of his foot, in a rock which is seventy cubits in length; and they [Muslims] say that Adam at the same time stood with his other foot in the sea. About this mountain are mines of rubies, opals and amethysts” (cf. Skeen 1871: 46). However, Soleyman refers to the mountain by the name of ‘Al-Rohoun,’ as mentioned by 9th century North Indian poet and dramatist Râjasekhara in his work *Balaramayana*. Paranavitana claimed that the early Arab travellers adopted this name, from which followed the use of ‘Al-Rohoun’ by the people of north India (1958: 17-20). Ruhuna is the ancient province (*ruhunurata*) to which Sri Pâda belonged. Van Sanden also writes of Abu Zayd, an Arab traveller in 910 CE, who described the country and its people, making references to the port of Galle as an entrepot, where goods from China and the Far East were traded for goods from the West and the Middle East (Aboosally 2002: 47).

Marco Polo, a Mediterranean merchant, in his voyage to the East, particularly to Sri Lanka and south India at the end of the 13th century, gave a brief description of his visit to island. According to his account, he did not visit Sri Pâda but repeated what he heard about Buddhist and Muslim pilgrimage to the sacred mountain. He wrote that the pilgrims went there to see a grave but did not mention whether it was that of Adam or Buddha. Moreover, he did not refer to Christian engagement with that grave, though he was well aware of the other Christian pilgrimage sites in the region, particularly the tomb of Saint Thomas in south India, to which Christians and Muslims travelled. He further confirmed in his account that, unlike Buddhists and Muslims, Christians were not engaging in Sri Pâda pilgrimages at this time because, “according to the Holy Scripture of our Church, the sepulchre of Adam is not in that part of the world” (cf. Yule 1875: 298-313). He must be right since the Christian,

more precisely Catholic, engagement with Sri Pâda began around the early 16th century with the advent of Western powers to the Indian subcontinent.

Like Marco Polo, a number of other travellers visited the island, but their accounts seemingly did not provide any reference to their visit to Sri Pâda. It seems what was reported about Sri Pâda was largely based on the stories given by other pilgrims, most likely Muslim. These accounts are very brief and straightforward. For example, the travel account of Odoric (Beatus or semi-saint of the Roman Church who travelled from 1316-30) as translated and edited by Colonel Henry Yule, explained:

In this country also there is an exceeding great mountain, of which the folk relate that it was upon it that Adam mourned for his son for one hundred years. In the midst of this mountain is a certain beautiful level place, in which there is a lake of no great size, but having a great depth of water. This they say was derived from the tears shed by Adam and Eve; but I do not believe that to be the truth, seeing that the water naturally springs from the soil. The bottom of this pool is full of precious stones and the water greatly abounded in leeches. (Yule 1913: 171)

There are other travel accounts, however, which reported their own experience of journeying to the sacred mountain. For instance, Giovanni de Marignolli, a monk in the Franciscan priory of Santa Croce in Florence, was journeying with some other monks to the tomb of St Thomas in Madras, but was caught in a storm and came to Sri Lanka in late 1340s. He gives an extensive account of the geographical and ecological surroundings of the sacred mountain, and describes how Adam made the sacred footprint there, his account also informing us of the growing popularity of the myth of Adam among Muslims at the time of his visit to the island (see Yule 1913).

For Muslim engagement at Sri Pâda, the account given by Ibn Battuta is worth excavating here. Battuta was born into a family of Muslim legal scholars in Tangier, Morocco, in 1304. He studied law as a young man, and in 1325 left his native town to make the pilgrimage, or hajj, to the sacred city of Mecca in Arabia. He travelled to many parts of the world in 1330 (1332) and ventured to India to seek employment in the government of the Sultanate of Delhi. In August 1344, Ibn Battuta and the ship crew arrived at the western port city of Puttalam in Sri Lanka, where he met the Tamil regional king of Chakkrawartti of the kingdom of Jaffna. Under the